Meridian Library Web Service - Product Vision

Meridian County Library Service | Digital Services Group | Document reference DSG/PV/014 | Version 1.4 | Owner: Head of Library Services | Review due: annually

1. Purpose of this document

This paper sets out why Meridian County Library Service commissioned a public web service, what it is for, who it serves and how we judge whether it is working. It is the standing reference for anyone taking on the service, whether that is a new member of the Digital Services Group or an external supplier.

2. Background

Meridian Library has served Fenner Road and the surrounding parishes since 1897 and is a registered charity (1042117) operating under a service agreement with the county. Until 2019 the only public-facing catalogue was a terminal in the Fenner Road reading room and a printed new-arrivals sheet posted to each branch every month. Members outside Fenner Road had no practical way of knowing whether a title was on the shelf before they travelled to a branch, and staff spent a substantial part of the working week answering the same questions by telephone.

The service was procured in 2019 from an external development partner under the county's minor works framework and went live in 2020. It has been extended twice since, most recently in 2023 when the staff console and the reporting pages were added. The original supplier relationship ended in 2024 and the service has been maintained in a caretaker capacity since then, with changes limited to content and to correcting faults.

3. What the service is

A single web application covering two audiences from one codebase:

- **The borrower catalogue.** Anyone may browse the catalogue, search it, see what is held at which branch, reserve a copy, look at their loans and manage their membership details. No sign-in is required to browse; membership matters only at the point of borrowing.
- **The staff console.** Branch and central staff use the same application to add items to the catalogue, run shelf audits, apply bulk actions to a selection of items, adjust branch and display settings, and pull the monthly lending figures.

The service covers all eight county branches - Fenner Road, Ashcombe, North Quay, Willowbank, St Mellick, Harrow Lane, Cadgwith and Penvale - although North Quay and Harrow Lane are presently closed to the public and appear in listings as closed.

4. Who uses it

4.1 Borrowers

Roughly eleven thousand active members. Membership is free to anyone living, working or studying in the county and allows twelve items at a time across all branches. Use is heavily weighted towards two groups: people over sixty, who make up a little under half of the catalogue searches recorded, and parents of primary-school children using the summer reading challenge and the events calendar. A meaningful minority of members reach the service from a public terminal in a branch rather than from their own device.

4.2 Library staff

About forty staff across the eight branches, of whom perhaps a dozen use the staff console daily. Staff are not technical and receive no formal training on the service beyond a half-day induction; the console is expected to be self-explanatory. Cataloguing is done at Fenner Road; the branches use the console mostly for shelf audits, bulk actions and printing labels.

4.3 The county

The county's culture and communities committee receives the lending figures quarterly and takes them from the reporting pages directly.

5. Goals

- A member should be able to find out whether a title is available, and where, without telephoning a branch.
- A member should be able to reserve a copy for collection at their home branch, and know what will happen next.
- Staff should be able to catalogue a new acquisition and place it on a shelf at a named branch without leaving the console.
- The monthly lending figures should come out of the service itself rather than being assembled by hand from branch returns.
- The service should work on an ordinary, elderly device on a slow connection, and should remain usable when scripting is limited.

6. Success measures

- Catalogue enquiries taken by telephone at Fenner Road: down by half against the 2019 baseline. (Achieved in 2022; holding.)
- Reservations placed through the web service rather than at a desk: above sixty per cent of all reservations.
- Items catalogued through the staff console rather than the legacy MARC loader: above eighty per cent for single acquisitions.
- Quarterly lending figures produced without manual reconciliation.
- No page of the public service taking longer than two seconds to render on the branch terminals.

7. Principles we hold to

- **Public first.** Everything a borrower needs is reachable without an account.
- **Plain pages.** The service is a set of documents, not an application shell. It must degrade gracefully.
- **Nothing served from elsewhere.** No fonts, scripts or images from third-party origins. The county's information governance position does not permit it.
- **Stable addresses.** Branch signage, printed leaflets and the county website point at specific pages. Routes are not to be renamed.

8. Accessibility

Meridian Library conforms to WCAG 2.1 Level AA. Last audited March 2024. The published accessibility statement is carried on the service and reviewed annually alongside this document.

9. What is out of scope

The service is not a library management system. Circulation, fines, membership records of record and inter-library loan all remain in the county's back-office system; the web service holds a fixed catalogue extract and displays it. There is no payment capability and no intention to add one. Digital lending (e-books and audio) is provided by a separate national platform and is linked to, not reproduced here.

10. Open questions

- Whether the two closed branches should continue to be listed at all.
- Whether the reporting pages should be moved behind the staff console rather than being publicly reachable, as they are today.
- Whether the service should be re-procured or brought into a supported arrangement. This paper assumes the latter.